Acceptance Criteria — Failure-Mode Checklist

Day 2 handout. The mental model for writing and triaging Acceptance Criteria: what an AC is, the 5 failure modes to check every AC against, and the happy / sad / weird coverage shape. Run every AC you write through the 5-failure list.

What an AC is (and isn't)

An AC is a **testable assertion** about the system's behavior in a specific situation:

```
Given <a precondition / starting state>
When  <an action or event happens>
Then  <an observable, falsifiable result>
```

IS	IS NOT
Testable (you can write a test that passes/fails)	"The system should be intuitive"
Specific to one behavior	"The system handles errors well"
Implementation-agnostic	"Use Redis to cache the response"
Falsifiable (you can prove it wrong)	"Performance should be good"

The 5 AC failure modes

Check every AC against all five. A good AC fails **none** of them.

#	FAILURE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	FIX
1	**Vague** ("intuitive", "fast", "easy")	"Then the user has a good experience"	Replace with a measurable outcome
2	**Untestable** (no observable result)	"Then the user feels confident"	Anchor to a system-visible action or state
3	**Restating the goal**	"Then dispatchers reconcile faster"	Pin to a specific in-system event, not a metric
4	**Multi-condition (AND-soup)**	"Then X and Y and Z and W happen"	Split into multiple ACs
5	**Implementation-prescriptive**	"Then a Redis cache hit returns…"	Describe behavior, not implementation

> The trickiest is **#3, Restating the goal**. Ask: *could this be tested without running an A/B against the metric?* If not, it's restating the goal.

Coverage shape — happy / sad / weird

A complete AC section covers three scenario categories. Aim for **8–12 AC total** with this shape:

PATH	QUESTION	TYPICAL COUNT
Happy	What does success look like end-to-end?	3–5
Sad	What happens when the user does the wrong thing or input is invalid?	2–4
Weird	Network drops, partial data, race conditions, edge cases the user wouldn't think of?	2–4

The **weird path** is where TPMs earn their seat. PMs who don't think technically miss it; engineers who don't think about users miss it differently.

Quick pass/fail sheet

AC #	PATH (H/S/W)	①VAGUE	②UNTESTABLE	③RESTATES GOAL	④AND-SOUP	⑤IMPL-PRESCRIPTIVE	CLEAN?
1							
2							
3							